title: "Affiliate Research Phase – Finding Tools That Pay You" subtitle: "How to find, apply, and get approved for high-commission programs" author: "Your Name / Trainer" date: "2026-04-21" version: "Final – Actionable Guide"

🧠 RESEARCH PHASE: WHAT YOU'RE LOOKING FOR

You're not just "finding tools."

You're finding:

👉 **Tools that pay you when someone signs up**

Focus on:

- High payout (≥ $30 per sale, or recurring)
- Easy approval (no minimum traffic requirements)
- Real demand (people are actively searching)

> **Trainer Note:** This is the step most beginners skip – they write content first, then realize the tools they reviewed don't have affiliate programs. Do this research **before** generating articles.

🔥 PART 1 — START WITH THESE PROGRAMS (GO HERE FIRST)

These are your "gold mines" – established networks with many financial/SaaS offers.

1. ShareASale

👉 https://www.shareasale.com

What to do:

- Sign up as a publisher (free)
- Once inside, search: "credit", "finance", "software", "SaaS"

What to say when applying to individual merchants:

> *"I run a niche content site focused on comparing financial tools and helping users choose the best solutions. My traffic is low right now because I'm in the content building phase, but I focus on high-intent, comparison-based articles."*

💡 **Suggestion:** Apply to 5–10 merchants at once. Some will reject; that's fine. The ones that approve are your starting point.

2. Impact

👉 https://impact.com

Search for: Credit tools, SaaS platforms, business software.
Many large brands (e.g., Intuit, Shopify, Canva) use Impact.

3. ClickBank

👉 https://www.clickbank.com

What to do:

- Go to "Marketplace"
- Filter by: **High gravity** (30+ means it converts well), **Finance / Business** niches
- Look for recurring billing products (e.g., subscription software)

Trainer Note: ClickBank has some low-quality products. Check the refund rate and gravity. Avoid anything that looks like a "get rich quick" scam.

4. Amazon Associates

👉 https://affiliate-program.amazon.com

Good for: Backup monetization, physical products (books, equipment).
Lower payouts (1–10%) but easy approval and huge inventory.

💰 PART 2 — DIRECT PROGRAMS (HIGH VALUE)

These are often better than networks because:

- Higher commissions (no network taking a cut)
- Dedicated affiliate managers
- Recurring payments

Credit niche (highly recommended):

- **Credit Strong** – Google "Credit Strong affiliate program"
- **Self Financial** – self.inc/affiliate
- **Experian Boost** – search "Experian affiliate program"

AI / SaaS niche:

- Search: `"(tool name) affiliate program"`
- Examples: Jasper AI, Copy.ai, SurferSEO, Canva Pro, Fiverr

💡 **Suggestion:** For direct programs, email their affiliate manager after applying. Introduce yourself and your content angle – it increases approval odds.

🔍 PART 3 — HOW TO FIND MORE (THIS IS THE REAL SKILL)

Go to Google and use these search formulas:

```
"best credit builder apps"
"best AI tools for small business"
"inurl:affiliate credit tools"
"credit builder affiliate program"
"tools like [popular tool] affiliate"
```

Then:

- Look at the sites ranking on page 1
- Scroll through their articles
- Note which tools they promote (those tools likely have affiliate programs)

Pro move (spy on competitors):

- Click the links in their articles
- See where they go – often it's an affiliate link (look for `?ref=`, `/affiliate/`, `&tag=`)
- That's their affiliate partner – apply directly.

🪜 PART 4 — HOW TO APPLY (STEP-BY-STEP)

Once you find a tool:

Step 1 – Find their affiliate page

Search: `tool name + affiliate program`
If not found, look for "Partners" or "Affiliates" in the footer.

Step 2 – Fill out the application

You'll be asked:

- **Website URL** – if your site is not live yet, say "in development, launching in [month]". Many programs accept this.
- **Traffic estimate** – be honest ("building content + SEO strategy, currently low but targeted").
- **Promotion methods** – "content site, comparison articles, social media (Pinterest, TikTok)"

Step 3 – Position yourself (use this template)

> *"I create comparison-based content that helps users choose the best tools. I focus on high-intent traffic and detailed reviews. My audience is [niche audience, e.g., people with bad credit looking to build their score]. I plan to promote your tool in my 'Best X for Y' articles and comparison pages."*

💡 **Suggestion:** If rejected, ask why. Many programs will tell you what they need (e.g., "come back when you have 1,000 monthly visitors"). Keep a list and reapply later.

🔗 PART 5 — HOW YOU GET YOUR LINK

Once approved, you'll receive a **unique tracking link**.

Example:

```
https://tool.com/?ref=yourname123
or
https://tool.com/affiliate?id=12345
```

That's how they track **your** clicks and sales.

Trainer Note: Never share your affiliate link publicly in a way that can be stolen (e.g., on a forum without a redirect). Use your own domain redirects (see Part 6).

🎭 PART 6 — "DISGUISING" LINKS (IMPORTANT)

Don't leave raw, ugly links in your articles. They look spammy and hurt trust.

Option 1 – Simple anchor text (no cloaking)

```
<a href="https://tool.com/?ref=yourid">Check pricing</a>
```

This is fine for most programs. Just make the anchor text natural.

Option 2 – Link cloaking (advanced, better for branding)

Use:

- **Pretty Links** (WordPress plugin)
- **Linkly** or **Short.io** (standalone)
- Or build your own redirect in Next.js:
  Create a page `/go/[tool]` that does a server-side redirect to the affiliate link.

Example:

```
yourwebsite.com/go/creditstrong → redirects to affiliate link
```

Why cloak?

- Looks cleaner
- Protects your commissions (some programs allow link theft if raw link is shared)
- Easy to update the destination without changing every article

💳 PART 7 — HOW YOU GET PAID

Each platform has different payment methods and thresholds.

Common methods: PayPal, bank transfer (ACH), Stripe, check.

Minimum payout thresholds:

- ShareASale: $25–$50
- Impact: $50
- ClickBank: $100 (varies)
- Amazon: $10 (gift card) or $100 (direct deposit)

Payment triggers:

- **CPA (Cost Per Action)** – you get paid when someone signs up (e.g., credit builder app)
- **Revenue share** – you get a percentage of the sale (e.g., 30% of first payment)
- **Recurring** – you get paid every month the customer stays subscribed **(BEST for passive income)**

> **Deep Dive:** Prioritize recurring programs. One customer paying $50/month for a SaaS tool can earn you $15/month forever. After 10 such customers, that's $150/month residual.

📊 PART 8 — WHAT TO LOOK FOR (DON'T SKIP THIS)

When evaluating a potential affiliate tool, ask:

✅ GOOD signs:

- $30+ one-time payout, or 20%+ recurring
- Trusted brand (users recognise it)
- Clear affiliate page with terms
- Dedicated affiliate manager or support
- Easy signup process (no minimum traffic)

❌ BAD signs:

- No clear payout information
- Scammy-looking product (fake reviews, hype language)
- No affiliate support (email bounces)
- Requires huge traffic upfront (10k+ visitors/month)

Trainer Note: Start with 3–5 good tools. You don't need 50 programs. A single high-performing tool can bring $200–$500/month by itself.

🧠 SIMPLE WORKFLOW (DO THIS TODAY)

Step 1 – Sign up for the big networks

- ShareASale
- Impact
- ClickBank
- Amazon Associates (optional)

Step 2 – Find 5–10 tools in your niche (credit OR AI)

Use the Google search formulas from Part 3.

Step 3 – Apply to all of them

Use the positioning template from Part 4.

Step 4 – Save everything in a tracking document

Use this simple table (copy into Google Sheets or Notion):

Tool Name	Network/Direct	Affiliate Link	Commission	Notes / Approval Status
Credit Strong	Direct	`https://...`	$100 CPA	Applied 4/21 – approved
Self	ShareASale	`https://...`	$50 + recurring	Pending
Jasper AI	Impact	`https://...`	30% recurring	Approved

Step 5 – Wait for approvals (1–7 days)

While waiting, continue researching and writing your content plan.

🔥 REALITY CHECK

You only need **3–5 GOOD tools** to hit $500/month.

Example:

- Tool A: $100 CPA, converts 2% → 10 sales/month = $1,000 (too optimistic, but shows potential)
- Realistic: 3 tools each converting 1–2 sales/month at $50 average = $150–$300
- Add a fourth tool with recurring commission = $50–$100/month residual

Volume wins: More articles = more traffic = more chances to convert.

🧭 FINAL MINDSET

You are **NOT**:
❌ Promoting random tools you found in 5 minutes

You **ARE**:
✅ Building a **decision engine** that matches users with the best solution – and getting paid when they choose.

> **Trainer Note:** This research phase is the foundation. If you skip it, you'll write 30 articles and then realise you can't monetise them properly. Do it right the first time.

👇 NEXT STEP (From Your Prompt)

After you gather your tools and have 3–5 approved affiliate links, say:

👉 **"ready to build with these tools"**

Then I will:

- Plug them into your Next.js app
- Build article templates around them (comparison tables, CTAs)
- Optimize the generator to insert the correct affiliate links automatically

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📎 Appendix – Quick Affiliate Program Cheat Sheet

Program Type	Examples	Avg Commission	Approval Difficulty
Credit / Finance	Self, Credit Strong, Experian	$50–$150 CPA	Medium (may ask for traffic)
AI SaaS	Jasper, Copy.ai, SurferSEO	20–40% recurring	Easy (no traffic required often)
Business tools	Fiverr, Canva, Shopify	$10–$100 CPA or revshare	Easy
Physical products	Amazon, Walmart	1–10%	Very easy

💡 **Suggestion:** Start with AI SaaS and business tools – they approve faster. Once you have traffic (1k+/month), apply to credit programs for higher payouts.

End of Research Phase Guide – Ready for PDF conversion.